

## NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

### ABOUT THE DEALS

Each Deal shows only your hand during the Bidding pages. You are asked to decide what bid/call you would make for the hand and when you have decided you click **BID** to go to the next page where the recommended bid is shown with any appropriate comments. This continues throughout the Bidding section, and when the final bid is made your partner's hand is also shown.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table. When you have the Plan in your mind, click **NEXT** to go to the next page.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer. When that happens a page will appear for you to click **ROTATE** to switch the hands so South becomes the Declarer. It is important to note that on this page the complete Bidding Auction is also rotated to correspond with South being Declarer. So if something in the plan depends upon the bidding this is the page to look at, not the earlier bidding pages.

The final page shows the full deal, including the East/West hands.

You may use the left Navigation panel to go to any numbered Deal you like, or you may just go to the next Deal by clicking the link at the bottom of the last page of a Deal.

### ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.

1NT Opening: 15-17 points

2NT Opening: 20-21 points

1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit

2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

**Stayman** convention is used extensively.

There is Stayman lesson on BakerBridge which can be reached by clicking Home on the menubar.

**Jacoby Transfers** are used extensively.

In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

There is a Jacoby Transfer lesson you can access by clicking Home.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.

Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

There is a lebensohl lesson you can access by clicking Home.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: North

Lead: ♠Q

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3♣

Declarer: East

Lead: ♥J

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♠

Declarer: South

Lead: ♣Q

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: West

Lead: ♥K

Board: 5

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: North

Lead: ♣10

**Board 1**

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K 9 7 4  
♥ J 10 4 3  
♦ J 7 6  
♣ 10 8

♠ A 6 3

♥ 9 7

♦ Q 8 4

♣ A K Q 6 2



♠ Q J 10 5 2

♥ Q

♦ A 9 5 2

♣ 9 5 3

♠ 8

♥ A K 8 6 5 2

♦ K 10 3

♣ J 7 4

| West        | North | East | South |
|-------------|-------|------|-------|
|             | 1NT   | Pass | 2♦    |
| Pass        | 2♥    | Pass | 4♥    |
| All Pass    |       |      |       |
| 4♥ by North |       |      |       |
| Lead: ♠Q    |       |      |       |

Who knows whether you should use a transfer or just bid 4♥ yourself. Assume you decide on the transfer and bid 2♦. Partner bids 2♥ (of course).

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Naturally you go ahead and bid 4♥, the final contract.

The contract would be 4♥ played by South.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠Q and West follows with the ♠9.

You win the first trick with the ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

The loser count is very confused, but that ♣ suit is not confused at all. You want to be able to run the ♣s so your plan is to play the ♥ A K, and if both defenders follow go ahead and knock out the last ♥ so they can't ruff your ♣ tricks.

Unfortunately when you play ♥ A K, East plays the ♥Q, then discards a ♠.

You may think you should change your plan but you should go right ahead with it. West has two master trumps, but dummy still has 4 small ones. So play a ♥ to force out West's ♥10. He will no doubt play another ♠ and force dummy to ruff. No problem, knock out West's final ♥ and dummy will still have one tiny trump left. When you get back in you can run the ♣s unimpeded.

Usually it is good technique to leave master trump(s) undrawn.

The exception is when you have a long suit you wish to run and you can't stand to have the running stopped by a ruff.

This Deal is unusual in that there are two master trumps, but the principle is the same.

**Board 2**

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 8 2  
♥ Q 9  
♦ J 7 3  
♣ J 9 8 6 3 2

♠ Q J 9 5 3

♥ K 4 3

♦ K 8 2

♣ 10 4

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ A 7 4  
♥ A 8 5 2  
♦ Q 10 9 4  
♣ A K

♠ K 10 6

♥ J 10 7 6

♦ A 6 5

♣ Q 7 5

|             |              |             |              |
|-------------|--------------|-------------|--------------|
| <i>West</i> | <i>North</i> | <i>East</i> | <i>South</i> |
|             |              | 1NT         | Pass         |
| 2♠          | Pass         | 3♣          |              |
| All Pass    |              |             |              |

3♣ by East

Lead: ♥J

Do you see it? The ♥8. Take the ♥A. Then play your ♣ A K. As predicted, the ♣Q doesn't fall. Then play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥9. Of course South will take the ♥10, but now your ♥8 is high.

As soon as you get the lead you play the ♥8 and discard dummy's ♠2.

We know, you didn't really play the ♥Q on the first trick in the hope that South had underled the ♥K (although he certainly might have done so).

The real reason for covering was so you could establish the ♥8 by force.

Suppose you had not played the ♥Q to trick one. North would have withheld the ♥K and you'd have had to take your ♥A. Later North would have taken dummy's ♥Q with his ♥K, then played a small ♥ through your ♥8 to South's ♥10 7.

The 2♠ bid is used as a transfer to 3♣.

If you don't use this in your system, just consider this hand; you might decide to incorporate it. So you bid 3♣ and everybody passes.

East plays 3♣. South leads the ♥J.

You play dummy's ♥Q hopefully, but North plays the ♥K.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

That is one loser too many. The ♣Q MIGHT drop . . . but she won't. There are no finesse positions. So you are going to have to establish a winner somewhere to discard dummy's small ♠.

**Board 3**

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 6 4

♥ K 6 5 2

♦ 10 7

♣ Q J 10 3

♠ A K J 7 3

♥ 8 4 3

♦ A 5 4

♣ K 9



♠ 2

♥ J 10 9

♦ J 8 6 3

♣ 8 7 5 4 2

♠ Q 10 8 5

♥ A Q 7

♦ K Q 9 2

♣ A 6

You could either use a transfer or you could jump to 3♠. You decide on the transfer and bid 2♥. Partner jumps to 3♠!

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The 3♠ bid is a "Super-accept", showing a maximum 1NT opener, 4 ♠s and a doubleton. In other words, partner's hand has revalued to 18 points. So you bid 6♠ (or you could ask for Aces instead).

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
|          |       |      | 1NT   |
| Pass     | 2♥    | Pass | 3♠    |
| Pass     | 6♠    |      |       |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

6♠ by South

Lead: ♣Q

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

The contract would be 6♠ played by North.

South plays 6♠. West leads the ♣Q, East follows with the ♣2.

You win the first trick with the ♣A in your hand.

There are two obvious possibilities for avoiding the ♥ loser. You could finesse East for the ♥K; this is a 50% chance. The ♦s could split 3-3; this is a 36% chance.

In fact, your chances are better than either of those percentages because you can try the ♦s first, and if they **DON'T** split you can then try the ♥ finesse.

Pull trumps; West shows up with 3 trumps. Play the ♦K, then a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A. On this trick West follows with the ♦10.

Your contract just became a sure thing! Play the ♣K to strip both your hands of ♣s. Lead dummy's last ♦, and when East plays low, finesse the ♦9. If the finesse wins, discard a ♥ from dummy on your good ♦. But if the finesse loses to West's ♦J, he will be endplayed and have to lead a ♥ into your ♥A Q or give you a ruff/sluff with a ♣. And on top of that your fourth ♦ will be good.

In this actual Deal your ♦ finesse worked which gave you 4 ♦ tricks.

But imagine that the ♦J is transposed to the West hand. He wins that ♦ trick but must give you the contract with his return.

**Board 4**

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A K 6  
 ♥ A 10 3  
 ♦ A 8 2  
 ♣ 10 9 7 4

♠ Q 9 2  
 ♥ K Q J 9 7 5  
 ♦ K Q 3  
 ♣ 6



♠ 8 7 3  
 ♥ 6 2  
 ♦ 7 5 4  
 ♣ A K Q 5 3

♠ J 10 5 4  
 ♥ 8 4  
 ♦ J 10 9 6  
 ♣ J 8 2

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
| 1NT      | 2♥    | 3NT  |       |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

3NT by West

Lead: ♥K

your two extra winners will be the ♣5 and ♣3.

Partner's jump to 3NT is a lebensohl method.

He is describing a hand with which he would have bid 3NT if there had been no overcall. But he is warning you that he **DOES NOT HAVE** a ♥ stopper!

Since you **DO** have a ♥ stopper you decide to pass and play 3NT.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♥K.

You hold up your ♥A until the third round.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 7

You need two more winners. Barring a 4-0 ♣ split

So after winning the ♥A, you play a ♣ to dummy's ♣Q and breathe a sigh of relief when both defenders follow suit.

UhOh. Surely you didn't play your ♣4 to dummy's ♣Q???

If you did then just look at the situation now. If the ♣J doesn't fall on the next trick the suit will be blocked. Now go back in time and play the ♣10 to dummy's ♣Q.

That's better. Now under the ♣ A K you can unblock the ♣ 9 7, which will leave you with the ♣4 to slip under dummy's ♣5.

Watch those spot cards. You may have to unblock them to stay in the hand you want to be in.

**Board 5**

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 6  
 ♥ Q 9 8 5 3 2  
 ♦ Q 10  
 ♣ A J 6 3

♠ A 4 2  
 ♥ A 6  
 ♦ A J 8 4 3  
 ♣ Q 7 2



♠ 10 8 7  
 ♥ 10 4  
 ♦ K 9 7 5  
 ♣ K 10 9 5

♠ K Q J 9 5 3  
 ♥ K J 7  
 ♦ 6 2  
 ♣ 8 4

| West        | North | East | South |
|-------------|-------|------|-------|
|             | 1NT   | Pass | 2♥    |
| Pass        | 2♠    | Pass | 4♠    |
| All Pass    |       |      |       |
| 4♠ by North |       |      |       |
| Lead: ♣10   |       |      |       |

You decide to use a transfer so the lead will be into whatever holding partner has in the minor suits. You bid 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

You decide to use a transfer so the lead will be into whatever holding partner has in the minor suits. You bid 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

You are nowhere near strong enough to be thinking of slam so you bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by South.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♣10. West wins the ♣A. They continue ♣s and you ruff the third one in dummy.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 3

Those losers are based on dummy's hand, not yours. You can figure them either way but it is usually easier to determine losers based on the long-trump hand. It's important to remember it in this Deal because the zero losers in ♥s assumes you will ruff a ♥ in your hand.

Pull one round of trumps with dummy's ♠K. Both defenders follow suit. Play the ♥A, then ♥6 to dummy's ♥K. On this trick East follows with the ♥10.

The Plan is still the same, you will ruff the ♥ in your hand, but you better be sure to ruff with your ♠A. Aha! Your precaution pays off when East shows out of ♥s, but of course he cannot over-ruff your ♠A.

A very good Bridge maxim is this: When you are ruffing, ruff with as high a trump as you can afford.

Here, with only 2 trumps left out, you can afford the ♠A.